

EXAMINED

HoMedics SoundSpa Portable SS-2000

One of the things that helps a lot of us concentrate better is the presence of suitable background noise. There are apps on the Play Store and websites that you can open up on a web browser that can do this for you, but every situation is not conducive to using either. In such cases, a dedicated white noise generator like the HoMedics SoundSpa SS-2000 can be useful. It is a small and light-weight white noise generator that does not take up too much space. It would fit comfortably on a nightstand or a bedside table. It can be powered by an AC adapter but can also work with 4-AA batteries for portability. However, putting in rechargeable batteries won't allow you to use the power adapter for charging the same. In terms of looks, the device looks sleek with a white exterior coupled with silver panels and controls. While there's no dedicated power switch, the volume knob doubles up as an off-switch when you set it to zero. You can also set a timer for 15, 30 or 60 minutes for the device to turn off on its own.

There are six different noise modes – White noise, Rain, Summer Night, Brook, Ocean and Thunder. There's very little bass response on the speaker unit on board, so sounds



like Thunder and Ocean fall short of making an impact. Also, the sound loops themselves could be better – there's not much thunder happening in Thunder, and the Ocean mode is way too windy. Due to the low power of the device, it also wasn't able to effectively mask exterior sound, like a colleague typing on a mechanical keyboard across the room.

A few other features were quite evidently missing from the SS-2000. For instance, it doesn't allow you to combine any of the onboard sounds, something that almost any white noise app on the web or smartphone allows. There's also no way to mount the SoundSpa Portable onto a wall or the roof, which would have been ideal in our opinion.

However, the SS-2000 is a pretty inexpensive and portable white noise generator that might serve the purpose in a relatively calm, small environment.

PRICE: ₹1,990

FiiO BTR3

The last year was quite eventful for Chinese HiFi brand FiiO in India, with multiple launches spread across the year. Alongside dedicated players like the M3K and the M7, FiiO also launched its latest portable Bluetooth receiver – the BTR3 – in India in September 2018. Following shortly after the BTR1 dongle, the BTR3 sports better capabilities with support for a wide range of audio codecs. While Bluetooth dongles are nothing new, FiiO products maintain a certain quality-price ratio that makes any successor to their product lines something to look forward to. The BTR3 sports an upgraded CSR8675 BT chipset. That entails an upgrade from Bluetooth 4.2 to 5.0, which is impressive on a dongle under 6k. Why is that a good thing? BT 5.0 makes 24BIT transmission possible due to the double transmission rate it is capable of, so full quality LDAC is a possibility. To take full advantage of this, the transmitter

also has to be 5.0 capable, but that is not too much to ask for, especially in 2019. With dimensions of 58×25×10.4mm (excluding the back clip) and weighing 26g (inclusive of the battery) with an aluminium body with a glass panel on the front, the BTR3 doesn't give anything to complain about in build quality but doesn't stand out either. The controls are also quite easy to use. FiiO has pulled off something ingenious on the BTR3 with the switched track navigation between the volume buttons. Due to the way it will be clipped on, the reversed track navigation controls feel intuitive and useful.

With the entry-level pricing on the BTR3, as well as increasing support for high-res Bluetooth audio on smartphones, this might be the right time to make the switch for anyone interested in transitioning to a wire-free world of audio. It is hard to find fault in what the BTR3 does. There's a ton of possibilities depending on what you plug it into, and regardless of your position on the wired vs wireless debate, this is one affordable Bluetooth DAC that you need to try out before judging it.

PRICE: ₹5,990

